

Three good tools, three different bets. **GlossGenius** optimizes for the solo stylist. **Vagaro** sells you a marketplace. **Boulevard** sells polish at a premium. **Plume Nexus** is built for the appointment-led salon that does walk-ins too — and has outgrown GG without wanting Boulevard's bill.

	PLUME NEXUS	GLOSSGENIUS	VAGARO	BOULEVARD
Built for	Hybrid appt + walk-in salons, 3–15 chairs	Solo & small beauty (1–5)	Small-mid salons, spas, gyms	High-end \$500K–\$5M+ salons
Price (top tier)	~\$49–149/mo · own processor	\$24–168/mo · flat 2.6%	\$30–105/mo + \$10/staff	\$235–435+/mo per location
AI reports	Ask anything, plain English	Static dashboards	Dense, no AI	None
Walk-in turn rotation	Yes — iPad kiosk + queue	Basic waitlist	Basic	Appointment-only
HR / payroll	Built in — 1099, comp, Gusto	None (→ QuickBooks)	Basic	Mid
Unified comms inbox	SMS + email + chat, one thread	SMS marketing only	Two-way SMS + MMS	Comms center (premium)
Payment processor	Stripe — you own fees & data	Locked in (flat 2.6%)	Locked to Vagaro Pay	Quoted per-merchant
Marketplace	No (by design)	No	Yes — new-client channel	No
Onboarding	Self-serve, minutes	Best-in-class, 15 min	Self-serve, dated UI	Guided, 2–4 weeks + CSM

WHERE PLUME NEXUS WINS

- ✦ **AI Reports chatbot** — “how did Tess do on Saturdays last quarter?” answered in seconds. None of the three ship this.
- ✦ **Walk-in + appointment in one tool** — turn-rotation kiosk bridges what GG, Vagaro & Boulevard split or skip.
- ✦ **Full HR & payroll included** — 1099 generation, compensation modeling, Gusto bridge — not a paid add-on.
- ✦ **Processor-agnostic on Stripe** — own your fees, your data, your terms instead of vendor lock-in.
- ✦ **One communications inbox** — SMS, email and in-app chat threaded per client.

HONEST TRADE-OFFS

- **No marketplace** — Vagaro can drive discovery; we won't. If a salon lives off Vagaro leads, switching has a cost.
- **Memberships & packages** — Vagaro and Boulevard have a decade of depth; ours covers the essentials.
- **Client-portal polish** — Boulevard & GG are ahead on self-service finish; we're closing fast.
- **No dedicated CSM** — Boulevard gives a human account manager; we're self-service by design.

THE 30-SECOND PITCH

GlossGenius is great until you have 5+ techs or want real marketing and reporting. Boulevard does everything but costs 3–5×. **Plume Nexus gives you Boulevard-class depth — plus AI reports, walk-in rotation, and built-in HR none of them ship — at GG-ish pricing, and you keep your own payment processor.**